

Sunday Message

TWENTY-FOURTH SUNDAY IN ORDINARY TIME

THE WORD

Year A • 13 September 2026 • Colour: Green • Psalter Week 4

TO FORGIVE WITHOUT LIMIT

MT 18:21-35



Peter asks Jesus how many times he should forgive someone. Jewish tradition said that God forgives three times and punishes on the fourth. Since human beings couldn't be more forgiving than God, forgiveness was, therefore, limited to three times.

Peter must have thought that forgiving someone seven times was more than generous, since it went far beyond what Jewish tradition taught. But Jesus says it's not enough; the Christian must forgive seventy times seven—in other words, never stop forgiving.

Jesus always showed mercy. As Pope Francis put it, the only people Jesus condemns are those who think they don't need it. "Jesus does not say, 'Blessed are those who plot revenge,' Pope Francis said. "He calls 'blessed' those who forgive and do so 'seventy times seven.' All of us have been looked upon with divine compassion. If we approach the Lord with sincerity and listen carefully, there may well be times when we hear his reproach: 'Should not you have had mercy on your fellow servant, as I had mercy on you?'"

In other words, we must forgive because God has forgiven us. We must never stop forgiving. ■

DO

Is there somebody you need to forgive or with whom you need to be reconciled? Perhaps you could seek them out this week.

SAY

"The Lord is compassion and love."

PRAY

For the Christian, there can be no limit to mercy and forgiveness. Pray for the strength to forgive always.

LEARN

Mercy was at the heart of Jesus' ministry

Forgiveness sets us free

We must think of ourselves as an army of the forgiven

REFLECT

What can we Christians say about forgiveness?

1. People are basically good. We have an innate goodness. The creation story in Genesis tells us God saw all that God had made and found it very good. In *Laudato Si*, Pope Francis uses a beautiful word to describe God's relationship with creation: All is a caress of God. When we see people as good, then we will treat them differently.
2. God forgives us first. That's the story of salvation. No matter how often God's people strayed, God never gave up on them. As Pope Francis puts it in his memoir *Hope*, we children get up to all kinds of things, we make mistakes, we sin, but when we ask for pardon, God's mercy embraces us and forgives us, always. God never tires of embracing and forgiving us. It is we who sometimes grow tired of asking for pardon. God never tires of forgiving us.
3. In receiving forgiveness, we give the past over to God - and let it go. We all know people who find this hard to do. They keep revisiting past sins. Crucified by scruples, they worry they didn't confess properly last time or didn't include everything. The

scrupulous aren't free. They've been so badly damaged by some event that they've been stuck ever since. Forgiveness sets us free, but not if we can't let go of the past. The challenge is to give the past over to God and live the present in love.

4. In order to live the present in love, we must be able to forgive ourselves. We can find that hard to do, especially if there's something in our past we feel especially guilty about. If I can't forgive myself, it's going to be hard to forgive others. If God can forgive me, then I must forgive myself.
5. Pope Francis described forgiveness as "a human right. The ability to be forgiven is a human right. We all have the right to be forgiven." In his letter on marriage and the family, *Amoris laetitia* (The Joy of Love), he says that pastors must "avoid judgements which do not take into account the complexity of various situations" and must "be attentive to how people experience distress because of their condition." All of us have been looked upon with divine compassion," he writes. "We should hear God saying to us, 'Should not you have had mercy on your fellow servant, as I had mercy on you?'"

Being compassionate, he continues, doesn't mean watering down church

teaching. Jesus proposed a demanding ideal, but "never failed to show compassion and closeness to the frailty of individuals like the Samaritan woman or the woman caught in adultery."

6. Conversion is always a work in progress. Pope Francis had a word for it: gradualism. In *Amoris laetitia*, he says that no one drops down from heaven perfectly formed; "families need constantly to grow and mature in the ability to love... All of us are called to keep striving towards something greater than ourselves and our families, and every family must feel this constant impulse."

My true self is something I must keep striving toward, turning from my old life to one like Christ's. My conversion is ongoing. I must work at being a better me, seeking to love more, forgive more, be kinder, more compassionate, more tolerant. I'll never be perfect, but I must keep trying. That's gradualism.

7. Forgiveness sets us free. To forgive is to stop wasting energy on resentment and grudges. In forgiving, I liberate myself to live. As Lewis Smedes put it in *Forgive and Forget*, "To forgive is to set a prisoner free and to discover that the prisoner was you." ■